In Praise of the Birth Stories

Jātakastava · Toh 1178 · Derge Tengyur

སྐྱེས་པ་རབས་ཀྱི་སྟོད་པ།

In Praise of the Birth Stories, known in Sanskrit as the Jātakastava and in Tibetan as Kyepa Rab kyi Töpa, is a devotional hymn in verse addressed to the Buddha. It celebrates the perfect conduct he showed in his former lives as a bodhisattva, recalling one birth story (jātaka) after another: the gift of his children and wife, the hare who offered his own body in the fire, the patience he kept while his limbs were hacked apart, the six-tusked elephant who gave up his tusks, King Śibi weighed on the scale to save a bird from a hawk, and the gift of his eyes and of his head. Its colophon names the master Jñānayaśas as its author and records that it was translated from an Indian manuscript by Dharmapālabhadra, the translator of Zhalu, and the Tibetan version sets the Sanskrit verses alongside their translation. The work is Toh 1178 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the Praises (stotra) section.

In the language of India: jātakastava

kṣedandāśavalaṃ guṇairaśavalaṃ caryāvibhutvaṃ vibho
janmasyandanikāvivarttanajaḍañcaita kvacedammama
yenāvandhyaphalodayastvayi bhavantyavyāhitāḥ yāṃśava
stenastutyanuvandhinā mukharanāmālambate bhāratī
cittālambhanalaṅgīnaḥ śamadṛśāmā

In the language of Tibet: In Praise of the Birth Stories.

All-pervading Lord who possesses the ten powers, the mastery of your unmingled conduct,
Unfolding through the stream of your births: how could this ever be mine, dull as I am?
Yet because toward you even a mere particle brings forth fruit that is not in vain,
These prattling words and names, bound up with praise, have taken hold of me.
Of those whose view is peace, who have passed beyond the objects of the mind,

veṇikāḥ saṅguṇā
vācāṃ gocaratāṃ tu yānnikalayā sthulāhi vomādṛśāṃ

ratnanyambunidherupābhupulineṣvāsirbhavantyarthinām
antarbhinnataraṃgadyautaruvakajyotsnāni grihṇāti kaḥ
yāvo bodhipathānuyānamahātāmutsāhinīkarmmaṇā
māmīllekahitodaye jinākṛyāvipyandinī santatiḥ
sainīkāpacitaḥ punati bhagavān saṃkīrtya

The supreme unshared qualities: only a coarse portion of them, such as this,
Has become the very domain of words for the likes of me.
It is as when, of the ocean's jewels laid bare upon the ridges of its sandy ground,
The needy take up, from among the many within, those that are deep, clear and radiant.
That continuum of yours which, through actions full of zeal for the Great Vehicle, following the path of awakening,
Brings benefit to me: your compassionate continuum, O Victor, with its ranks, purifies; O Blessed One, rightly proclaimed,

mānādradhunājheyābhogavisāriṇo gatamālāḥ prāgeva bodhau guṇaḥ
uddāmadviradasya rāgavarśino vṛttiṃ puronmādinī
mālokyāvyativartinā praṇihihā bodhodhiyo yantvayā
vinyasyanta ivāmarāstvayi ciraṃ dharmābhiṣekaśriyante
nākampitakeśarāntamasṛjanapuṣpopahāraṃ divaḥ
kṣuddukhaglapitodarī giridarīrāntranta

Now, what need is there to speak of the qualities of awakening, stainless, rich with all that can be known?
Before the maddening frenzy of an elephant in rut, in the grip of lust,
You could not be turned back, once you had set out for your awakening.
Like the splendor of the Dharma empowerment the gods long ago conferred on you, your pure mind was firmly set;
Therefore upon the tips of the mane at your neck they showered flowers as an offering.
Wasted by the suffering and sickness of hunger, within a mountain gorge

ralasthitāṃ
dṛṣṭrā śāvakaghātanaikarabhasāṃ vyāghrīṃ dayāghrātadhīḥ
yastvaṃ valkalinīṃ jaṭijanavatīṃ murtiṃsmutsṛṣṭavān strāṇantena bhavān bhavādrivivaravyāvartināṃ dehināṃ
yātpraleyasitopalādrivahalaṃ mātaṃgatāṃ vibhatā kāntārāṃ naravartināṃ

tanubhṛtāmucchittaye vyāpadām
śailendraṃ śithilopalaṃ calayatā muktastva

A tigress had come to dwell. Seeing her set about devouring her cubs, you, with a mind bent wholly on saving them out of compassion,
You who had bound and tied your matted locks with bark, gave up your body completely;
Therefore you are the protector of the embodied beings who circle in cyclic existence through the caverns of the mountain of becoming.
Assuming the very form of an elephant, a mountain of white stone,
For the embodied men wandering in the wilderness, deprived of drink,
You made the king of mountains with its loosened rocks shake, and cast your very self

taṭātra
manyematsariṇāṃ nitāntamalināste nakṣatāvṛttayaḥ
yallokāmbaracandra candravapuṣā candraprabhatve tvayā
kalmāṣāntaśikhaṃ śikhāmaṇirucā dattaṃ tvajāyārthane
nālāllūnamipāravindamasināpyotkṛtramūlaṃ śira
stenaiṣāñjagatāṃ gatosi gurutāmuṣṇīṣvanmūrdhani
bālānbālasarojakomalatanūnyatpu

From the cliff's edge. By this, I think, the conduct of the miserly, so full of stains, was impaired.
When you, O moon in the sky of the world, whose body is like the moon, were Candraprabha,
You gave a begging brahmin your head, with its topknot that puts an end to faults, radiant with its crest jewel,
Its root severed by a sword like a lotus cut from its stalk.
Therefore you stand at the head of these beings, like the crown protuberance (uṣṇīṣa) of the most exalted.

The children, tender in body as young lotuses born of the lake,

trakānārthana
paryāstāhnacalacchikhaṇḍakabhṛtodārāṃścabhābānugān
prādāṃstyaṃ jinatena nūnamabhabanmāraṅganānāṃ mukhaṃ saṅgobāñcitapakṣmalocanadalaṃ yajñālasāmantharaṃ
śayyasvabīcāriṇā banabhūtrā purā pakṣiṇā
bhinnāśeṣakaleje gatyabikale jyāyaḥ pthāśaṃsinā
bistāraṃ gamitaṃ pratatāṃynnātha kā

Your sons with their sidelocks you gave to a supplicant,
And your wife as well, the foremost, in accord with you.
By that, O Victor, on the lips of Māra's daughters, their lashes and petal eyes as though caught in a net, the sweet words faltered.
When, as a village bird on the forest ground, discerning in matters of bed and sleep,
You praised to beings of every kind without exception, complete and lacking nothing, the path of the elders,
And the vow you took up spread far and wide,

biñjalaṃ
tenājñāmarutāṃ girīṭakiraṇacchāyaṃ yāspadaṃ pogatā
yatparṇṇambuphalāśinīśaśatanuṃ tvaṃ nātha bibhratpurā
tatkālātithaye kṛpāricayā dātiṣyamābedanayana
āḥrūḍhaḥsphuṭabisphuliṅgamanalantenādhunapikṣitā
bindomaṇḍalalvañcanaṃ śaśamayaṃ yuṣmaryaśo lakṣyate
yatkopāruṇadṛṣṭinā kala

By that, O Protector, knowledge reached a station lovely with the radiance of crowns.
When you, O Protector, bore the body of a hare that fed on leaves, water and fruit,
Then, thoroughly practiced in compassion for a guest, you knew yourself to be the gift,
And entered the fire with its streaming sparks, from then on without concern.
Upon the maṇḍala of the orb, the mark whose very nature is a hare displays your fame.
When one whose glance was red as the dawn with anger

bhubākṛtvā bhrubobhaṅganīlekhāmullasitāsinā bidalitapraṅgamāsaṅginā
tvāmāsītakṣaṇamapyabikṣatadhiyaṃ tyaktumānakṣamānyetena
niraṅkuśāḥsmaraśarāḥpuṅkheṣu bhadgadgatā
yaddveṣīhariṇācirātanadhanutanadhanurdantestvayā'bhyarcitaḥ ṣaḍdantena
satāsitonnatabṛhajjīmūtapuñjatviṣā
kośākarṣaṇabāntabhūrirudhira

Knit his brows in rippling lines and with a sword hacked apart your limbs and flesh,
Patience, I think, could not bring itself to abandon you even for an instant;
Therefore the unrestrained arrows of Smara (Kāma, the god of love) were

broken.
When you honored with your tusks the hostile plunderer, long a bearer of the bow,
You, the six-tusked one, white and lofty, blazing with light like a mass of the gods' rain clouds,
Drew them from their sockets,

kṣodāruṇaistenabaḥ
pātālepibhujaṃgameḥślathaphaṇairadyāpidaṃṣṭārcyata
saṃrambhatphaṇināṃ phaṇāhaticalāṅbhīmormimālādapāmpatyuryatmakacch
aṭābilulitātparyastanaukānarāḥ
premṇākāyamahāpmabena bhabatā tīrānnamāpāditā tatkarmātiśayena tena nikhilālokāḥ klatrīkṛtā
śai

With a great and terrible gush of blood.
Even in the underworld, the serpents with lowered hoods still worship the tusks.
Hoods reared in fury, the lord of waters (the ocean) heaving with its terrible garlands of waves, its sea monsters:
With your body, O great Victor, you brought them to the shore.
By that surpassing deed, all without exception shone.

lātmaṇḍalino bilaṅghya biṣayāṃstoyābalīmekhalānra
yaccintāmaṇināṇareṇyabadaradvīpānnarālodarātra
labdhvapūrṇṇaphalātvayāpraṇayināmāśābabandhākṛtā
stvattastenasamudbhabanti biduṣāṃ saddharmmaratnāṅkurāḥ
sāndrambāntabitānanīlapapuṣāmojomupaṃrakṣasāṃ
khaḍgotkṛttadalairbibāṭitaśirārandhrasraballohitaiḥ

Having passed beyond the maṇḍala of the mountains, with its necklace of garlands and its girdle,
When you obtained the wish-fulfilling jewel from the depths within Badaradvīpa,
You made it bear full fruit; and so from you the sprouts of the precious true Dharma have sprung for the wise.
The rākṣasas, their bodies blue as a canopy, full of splendor,
With the blood that dripped from the openings of the veins, cut and split by the sword,

yatmāsairakṛpāḥ kṣudhābyupaśamaṃ
sairabyapetopsabhiryogājanmarudhobhabhodbhavatṛṣāmucchedinastenabaḥ
śyenottasabiśuṣkapambitagalasyotsaṃgasaṃsapiṇo
yanniḥsaṃgaratāśibāyaśibinārajñāmatāpakṣiṇaḥ
raktoṅgārakalaṃkitātulatulāmāropitātetanurmārastendukūlapakṣmataralaṃ
nītastulālāghabaṃ
lakṣme

Those merciless ones had their hunger stilled; through the yoga of your own free choice, the thirst that arises from birth and becoming is cut off.
Terrified by the hawk, parched, its throat choked, was the bird;
Though King Śibi, delighting in non-attachment, for the sake of peace, weighed blood for the bird upon the scale,
Māra made the body as light upon the scale as a speck of dukūla silk.

mabyabadhūyabāñcitaphalāmākhaṇḍamāghyaṃsināṃ
yattiryagnatīsandhibandhamadhamaṃ kṛtvā bhabān jainmināṃ
cakremarmabhidāṃ rujāṃ svapiśitaiḥ prābandhakīnāṃ śamaṃ
tenakleśabiṣacchidāṃ tabadhiyāmabyāhatāḥ śaknayaḥ
yatsandohamibaśriyā phalamibaprocchrayibuṇyaujasaṃ
digdāṃ naktakaṇaiḥ sphuratkubalayacchāyābhinīlāyataṃ

Glory, though longed for, trembled, and the fruit of desire became a light fragment.
When you accepted the lowly bond of rebirth as an animal for your birth,
Those held fast by diseases that strike the vital points of the cakras you brought to peace with your own flesh;
By that, your mind, which cuts off the poison of the afflictions, has unobstructed power.
When, like a doubt, like the fruit of glory and of merit,
Beautiful as the droplets strewn by night and as the utpala lotus, deep blue and wide,

utpāṭyākṣaṇidvaṇaṃ dvayasadārbipāyaniścakṣuṣe
tenandhasyatamasvatosyajagatastuṅgaikadīpo bhabāna
ityātmārthanibandhikena mṛṣibākyalaṃ darśitaṃ
leśasyāpinakīrtanañjinakṛtaṃ tvadbarṇṇarāśermmamā
tārabdhānpatāñjalaṃ jalapurāmākarṣatā bāridhe
belānteśvibarodhasvājalalabacchedohasaṃlakṣyate
tvaccaryātiśayāṃśaleśaracanādyaḥśre

Your two unblemished eyes you plucked out for an eyeless brahmin;
By that, for a world blind in its own darkness, you are the one lofty lamp.
Thus, bound by my own purpose, I have displayed the ornament of the sage's words.
O Victor, I have proclaimed the mass of your praises, if only in part.
Having gained this, as one who draws fresh water from the ocean, the city of waters,
At the limits of its tides, as with water, a cutting-off is clearly shown.
Your surpassing conduct

yasāmudbhaba
saṃbhārobibulaprasādabikasadbhaktyacitāṃśasyame
tenātyantaparopakāranirtaḥ svārthebimandādaro
bhūyatsarbabidāṃ parārthabiduṣāṃ yānaikatānojaṇaḥ
jātakastapa ācāryājñāyaśasaḥ

This was translated from an Indian manuscript into the Tibetan language by the translator of Zhalu, the monk Dharmapālabhadra.

Of which I have set out a mere small portion: the vast accumulation that has arisen for me from this good,
Mine through a share made dense with devotion that blossoms in clear faith,
By it may beings, wholly delighting in benefiting others and caring little for their own aims,
Become single-minded in the vehicle of the all-knowing ones, who are skilled in the welfare of others.

In Praise of the Birth Stories was composed by the master Jñānayaśas.

Translator's Notes

• This piece interleaves the Sanskrit verses with the Tibetan translation, and the Tibetan breaks off mid-verse where the Sanskrit resumes; the English follows the Tibetan in its own order. Here □□□□□ renders the continuum of the Bodhisattva's lives (santati), not "tantra", and □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is "putting an end to faults", not Antaka (Death). □□□□ in the elephant verse is the verb "I think". □□□ is read as □□□□ ("like"), an evident copyist's slip. □□□ is taken as "now". □□□□□□□□□□ is taken as "deprived of drink" (the lost travellers of the elephant story); this is uncertain. In the jewel simile the Tibetan lacks the rhetorical question ("who takes the jewels deep within?") implied by the verse; it is translated as the Tibetan stands.
• The piece alternates Sanskrit verse lines, given in romanization, with the Tibetan rendering; the English follows the Tibetan in its own order. Here □□□□□ is Smara, the god of love, not mindfulness; □□□□ is the "cutting-off" of a little water, not the doctrinal term annihilation; and □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is King Śibi. □□□□□□□, literally "village bird", is the bird of the jātaka on honoring elders. □□□□□ is read as □□□□□ ("thoroughly practiced"), an evident copyist's slip.

Some of the Tibetan follows the Sanskrit word by word and misreads it: "like a doubt" (□□□□□□□□□□□) answers Sanskrit sandoham iva, "like an abundance", and "the vital points of the cakras" answers the Sanskrit verb cakre, "made"; both are translated as the Tibetan stands. In the Śibi verse the Tibetan makes Māra the one who renders the body light. The lines on the serpents' worship and on Glory trembling are obscure and rendered tentatively.
• □□□□□□□□□□□□□ could also be read "in the one vehicle"; the Sanskrit verse (yānaikatāna, "intent solely on the vehicle") supports "single-minded in the vehicle", which is followed here.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.